



YOU OFTEN WISH YOU WERE DEAD

BATTLE OF PASSCHENDAELE (1917)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

World War I

BEFORE

1870–1871 Defeat for France in the war against Prussia leads to the creation of a powerful German Empire.

1887 Germany orders large shipbuilding initiatives.

1912 The Balkan Wars erupt, hardening Austro-Hungarian attitudes to Serbia.

1916 Secret meetings between Britain and France produce the Sykes–Picot Agreement, splitting the Ottoman Empire.

AFTER

November 9, 1918 Kaiser Wilhelm abdicates, and his imperial government collapses.

1919 At the Paris Peace Conference, stiff terms are imposed on Germany by the victors in the Treaty of Versailles.

Passchendaele, officially known as the Third Battle of Ypres, was a large-scale attack against the German front line around Ypres, Belgium, during World War I. The Allies' aim was to advance into Belgium and free the German-held ports on the Belgian coast, which the Germans had been using



Soldiers at Passchendaele fought in appalling conditions. In the absence of anything better, these machine-gunners are using bomb indentations as makeshift shelter.

to attack British shipping. The biggest challenge was to break through the defensive positions taken by the Germans on the West Flanders Ridge. Key to the breakthrough was seizing the village of Passchendaele.

Preparations for the battle began on June 7, 1917, with a heavy two-week bombardment of German positions. The infantry offensive began on July 31, 1917. Within days, the Allied forces were stuck in mud as torrential rain turned the area into a quagmire. By the time the Allies—made up of British, French, Canadian, and Australian troops—captured Passchendaele on November 6, the village was in ruins. The conflict cost 300,000 Allied lives, with a gain of 5 miles (8km), while the Germans lost 260,000 of their troops. It was hailed as a victory by the British government but became a byword for the utter futility of war.

Secret diplomacy

Two main disputes led to World War I: one between Germany and France, and the other between Russia and Austria-Hungary. The long history of mutual antipathy between Germany